



“I hate to shoot a Hun down without him seeing me, for although this method is in accordance with my doctrine, it is against what little sporting instincts I have left.”

JAMES MCCUDDEN VC, 1917

KNIGHTS OF THE AIR

WHILE BRUTAL TRENCH WARFARE BOGGED DOWN THE ARMIES, THE MYTH OF FIGHTER PILOTS AS “KNIGHTS OF THE AIR” SUPPLIED A PUBLIC NEED FOR HEROES

WORLD WAR I was the first total war, in which the entire human resources of industrialized societies were mobilized in the drive for victory. The mass slaughter in the trenches put an immense strain upon social solidarity and morale. Even with deep reserves of patriotism to draw upon, political and military leaders recognized that popular support for the war might evaporate. Fighter pilots offered a welcome supply of heroes to be used as a focus for patriotic enthusiasm.

The French and Germans created a formalized system for allotting “ace” status to a flier based on a certain number of confirmed kills – a number that had to be raised in the course of the war as air combat intensified. The British high command never formally accepted the existence of aces but awarded a few of the highest scoring pilots the Victoria Cross, their most coveted military decoration. Aces were turned into celebrities by patriotic publicity machines. Their faces decorated the front pages of newspapers; they were



AMERICA'S TOP ACE

A former racing driver and military chauffeur, Captain Eddie Rickenbacker was the most successful American fighter pilot of World War I, with 26 kills.

filmed for movie newsreels; they were showered with honors; and their funerals were occasions of national mourning. When French ace Georges Guynemer was killed in 1917, his name was inscribed on the walls of the Panthéon, alongside France's greatest philosophers and poets.

Soaring above the trenches

The propaganda worked because it fed a widely felt nostalgia for a cleaner, nobler form of warfare. The idealism felt by some at the start of the war – poet Rupert

Brooke described entering the conflict as “like swimmers into cleanness leaping” – found no satisfaction in the squalid attrition of the trenches. Airmen seemed, morally as well as literally, to soar above the cratered mud of Flanders. This was war as it was meant to be – an opportunity to demonstrate the



RED BARON'S MOUNT

Anthony Fokker based his highly maneuverable 1917 Dr.1 triplane, of which the above is a modern replica, on the Sopwith Triplane, whose three wings gave it extra lift and agility. It gained notoriety as the mount of Baron Manfred von Richthofen, who claimed 19 of his 80 victories in it.

